

## CORE FORMULA

**Ask -> Tell -> Ask -> Ask: "What's your sense of this so far?" -> Tell: the one point that matters, concisely. -> Ask: "How does that land?" -> Field rule: use the structure to organise your thinking, then speak like a person.**

## MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Ask one real question about where they are, tell one clear point, then ask what they make of it.

## BEST FOR

- Teaching or explaining something new
- Giving feedback
- Clinical or medical explanations
- Coaching conversations
- Sharing complex information without overwhelming
- Making a concise, memorable contribution in a meeting

## PHRASE BANK

### Opening asks · Find their starting point

- "What's your sense of this so far?"
- "Where are you with this already?"
- "What do you already know about it?"
- "What's your read on it?"
- "Before I jump in - what's your starting point?"
- "How much of the background have you got?"
- "What's your gut feeling on it?"
- "What have you tried so far?"

### Warm framing · Before you tell

- "I want to make sure this is actually useful to you."
- "Tell me where you're up to and I'll fill the gaps."
- "I'd rather meet you where you are than talk over your head."
- "There's no wrong answer here - I just want your starting point."
- "Whatever you already know, we can build from there."
- "I'll keep this short, and you tell me if it helps."
- "Let me check I'm being useful and not just talking."

### Meetings, email and status · Work contexts

- "Quick context check: what's already landed with everyone?"
- "Here's the one thing that matters, then I'll take questions."
- "The headline is X; the detail is only there if you want it."
- "I'll give you the short version - say if you need more."
- "Where's the group on this before I share the update?"
- "I've put the main point first so you can scan it."
- "That's the key point. What would make it clearer for the decision?"

### The point and the closing ask · Tell then check

- "Here's the key point, in one line."

- "The main thing is X; the rest is only support."
- "That's the core of it. How does that land?"
- "What do you make of that?"
- "Does that match what you were expecting?"
- "What's your reaction to that?"
- "What questions does that raise for you?"
- "What would you do with that?"

#### **When the structure misses · Reset and simplify**

- "I made that too structured - let me say it more simply."
- "That may not be the useful frame. Let me back up."
- "I don't want the structure to override the actual issue."
- "What part of that was useful, and what should we drop?"
- "Let me try that again in plain words."
- "I think I lectured a bit there. What's the real question?"
- "Forget the framework - what do you actually need from me?"

#### **Feedback and sensitive moments · Handle with care**

- "Can I share what I'm seeing, and then hear your take?"
- "Before I give feedback - what's your own read on how it went?"
- "Here's the one thing I'd change. How does that sit with you?"
- "What have you been told so far?"
- "I'll tell you the main point plainly, then we can sit with it."
- "What matters most to you to understand right now?"
- "Is this a good moment for the detail, or do you need a minute?"

### **WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST**

1. Weak: Using Ask-tell-ask as a visible script, naming each step and sounding rehearsed.  
Better: Using Ask-tell-ask silently to organise a concise response.  
**Best: Using it flexibly, then checking whether the listener is clearer, more heard, or better able to respond.**
2. Weak: Telling everything you know in case some of it turns out to be useful.  
Better: Telling the one key point and stopping.  
**Best: Telling the one point, then genuinely asking what they make of it.**
3. Weak: Asking "Make sense?" as a full stop.  
Better: Asking an open question at the end.  
**Best: Asking, then letting their answer change your next sentence.**

### **DECISION TREE**

#### **If The listener needs speed**

Use the shortest version - one-line ask, one-line tell, one-line ask.  
*"Quick sense-check: does this land?"*

#### **If The listener needs support**

Validate first and delay the framework until the emotion settles.  
*"That sounds hard. We can get to the detail when you're ready."*

#### **If The listener needs a story or example**

Switch to an example-oriented neighbour such as STAR or CARL.  
*"Let me give you a concrete example instead."*

#### **If The listener needs action**

End with one clean next step rather than an open reflection.  
*"So the next step is X - does that work?"*

### If The listener already understands

Drop the Tell entirely; confirm and move on.  
"Sounds like you've got it - anything I can add?"

## SCENARIOS

### Work meeting

Check what's already landed, give one point, invite reaction - keeps your contribution concise and memorable. —  
"Where's everyone on this? The key point is the deadline moved. What does that change for you?"

### Email or written update

Put the main point first, keep the tell to short paragraphs or bullets, end with an open question. — "Quick check on where you're up to. Here's the one change. What would you want to know next?"

### Giving feedback

Ask what kind of feedback would help before you structure anything. — "What's your own read on how it went? Here's the one thing I'd change. How does that sit?"

### Difficult conversation

Use one sentence per step and pause between them; don't stack. — "What's your sense of where we are? Here's what I'm worried about. What do you make of it?"

### Explaining something technical

Find their starting point so you don't over- or under-explain. — "How much of this have you used before? The bit that trips people up is X. Want to try it?"

### Clinical or high-stakes information

Ask what they already understand, tell the main point plainly, ask what it raises - with extra care. — "What have you been told so far? The main thing is X. What questions does that bring up?"

## WHEN NOT TO USE

- Token collaboration where the questions are for show, not genuine input
- Urgent commands, where a single direct instruction is what's needed
- When the person has already declined your advice
- When physical safety or an emergency response takes priority
- Raw emotional moments where listening, validation or repair should come first
- When the person clearly already understands - telling would only pad the moment

## 7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

### Day 1 — Spot the urge

Notice three moments today when you're about to explain something. Just catch the urge to tell before you ask - no need to change anything yet.

### Day 2 — Write one

Take a real situation and write a 60-second response using Ask -> Tell -> Ask. Mark the three parts so you can see them.

### Day 3 — Cut it

Cut that response by a third without losing the core point. The Tell should end up as one clear line.

### Day 4 — Two voices

Say it aloud twice - once as a visible structure, once as plain speech. Keep the plain version and drop any step labels.

### Day 5 — Open the ask

Rewrite your closing question so it can't be answered with just "yes". Use it once in a real conversation and watch what it opens.

### Day 6 — Recover on purpose

In a live conversation, notice if the structure misses and practise one recovery line to reset without defending the framework.

### Day 7 — Full run

Use the whole move once with someone real: ask their starting point, tell one point, ask what they make of it - and let their answer change what you say next.

## **AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST**

- Did I use Ask-tell-ask to serve the listener, or to sound polished?
- Did I find out what they already knew before I told them?
- Was the core point clear and short?
- Did the final ask actually invite a response?
- Did I adapt when they needed something else?
- Did I preserve their autonomy and dignity?